

Proposal for a Revised Structure of the MA Programmes in Political Science (MAPS) and International Administration and Global Governance (IAGG)

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Current problems and motivation for change

The Department of Political Science strategy for 2025–2027 identifies the development of competitive educational programmes characterized by high expectations and a strong scientific foundation as a central goal. The proposed changes are aligned with this objective.

The new structure and content of the MA programmes in Political Science (MAPS) and International Administration and Global Governance (IAGG) aim to address several challenges in the current advanced-level education structure, while remaining mindful of budget constraints (approximately 5483 clock hours, plus additional hours generated by fee-paying students) and the allocation of approximately 141 full-time equivalent (FTE) students.

The proposal is based on a yearly admission of approximately 33 students to MAPS and 33 students to IAGG, in addition to approximately three fee-paying students per programme. Furthermore, we expect around six students per programme to participate in the double degree programmes with the University of Konstanz (spending one year at the University of Gothenburg).

All calculations are approximate.

Issues with the structure and content (before Fall 2026)

- Insufficient progression in methods (and limited opportunities for methodological specialization)
- Absence of general courses in the main sub-disciplines of Political Science (i.e., no courses specifically designed for political science students)
- Limited progression between the programmes' substantive courses
- Course structures that rely heavily on lecture-based formats more typical of bachelor-level instruction
- An inflexible course structure overly dependent on a few research programmes (V-Dem, QoG, PerDem, MOD)
- A cost structure that is difficult to sustain within current resource constraints

It should be noted that none of these issues imply that individual courses in the current programmes are of poor quality. Rather, these points highlight systemic challenges that require comprehensive structural changes. The proposed reforms outlined below are intended to address these structural challenges.

It should also be noted that while several of these issues primarily concern MAPS, this proposal introduces changes to both MAPS and IAGG. The proposed changes simplify the overall structure and planning of advanced-level education at the department and allow us to offer a broader variety of courses for both programmes by pooling resources.

The proposed changes will also ease administrative work to some extent. Since student choice will be concentrated to two occasions — the elective semester and the methods course (for IAGG students) — administrative costs related to admission to elective courses will decrease and overall predictability in student numbers will improve. Moreover, the proposal combines flexibility in course choice with lower administrative costs, since the elective master seminars will be administered as one course, or at most two courses, in each module.

Reforms already decided for Fall 2026 admission

Several decisions regarding revisions to our programmes were taken during Fall 2025 and will be implemented from admission in Fall 2026:

- We will introduce a new course in research design for MAPS students: *Research Design in Political Science* (SK2302), 7.5 credits. [Course plan for SK2302](#).
- The former *Political Science Analysis* (SK2121) has been shortened to 7.5 credits and renamed *Introduction to Political Science Analysis* (SK2122).
- A new course, *Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences* (SK2301), 15 credits, replaces *Applied Statistical Analysis* (SF2321). [Course plan for SK2301](#).
- MAPS students admitted from Fall 2026 will choose between two methods courses in their first semester: the new SK2301 or the course *Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists* (SF2324).
- A new elective methods seminar course, *Methodological Specialization* (SK2303), 15 credits, will be available for MAPS students in their third semester (from Fall 2027).
- The Master's programme in Political Science: Environmental Governance and Behavior (MAPS(e)) has been paused from Fall 2026.
- The course *Environmental Problems within Social Science: From Tragedy of the Commons to Planetary Boundaries* (SK2223), 15 credits, has been paused from spring 2027.
- Admission to both programmes is now primarily based on applicants' grades.

The reforms implemented from Fall 2026 address several issues in the earlier versions of the programmes. In particular, the introduction of the new courses strengthens research design and methods training in MAPS and creates clearer progression

in quantitative methods. The dedicated research design course prepares students for subsequent methodological training and reduces the need to cover research design fundamentals within the methods courses themselves. In addition, pausing the MAPS(e) programme and one of the existing courses reduces costs.

For reference, the updated programme syllabi for the MA programmes from admission in Fall 2026 are available at the following links:

[Syllabus for MAPS](#)

[Syllabus for IAGG](#)

Proposed changes from admission Fall 2027

In order to address the remaining issues, I propose further changes to both programmes.

The introduction of specialized core courses in sub-disciplines in political science

The current programme structure includes only one course, *Introduction to Political Science Analysis*, that introduces the main sub-disciplines of political science in general terms. All other courses in the political science programme are thematic and primarily cover topics within comparative politics.

By introducing specialized courses in three core sub-disciplines exclusively for political science students — comparative politics, political behavior, and public administration — the programme will provide a more solid and in-depth education in the discipline. Since all students will take the same courses in the first year, it will also be possible to build progression both between the first and second semesters and across the three core courses. These courses can incorporate both classic and contemporary works within each sub-discipline.¹

The introduction of master seminar courses and methods seminar courses

The proposal introduces two types of seminar courses: *master seminar courses*, which focus on specific themes within particular sub-disciplines or cross-disciplinary topics, and *methods seminar courses* (including the course already decided on, SK2301), which give students the opportunity to specialize in specific research methods.

During the elective semester, students will be able to choose from several master seminar courses and methods seminars (partly implemented for MAPS students admitted in 2026). The intention is to offer topics within the same sub-disciplines as the specialization courses (comparative politics, political behavior, and public administration), while also allowing students to broaden their studies. Such broadening may occur through seminars in other sub-disciplines, such as political theory, or through seminars focusing on specific themes, such as environmental politics or gender and politics.

¹If greater representation of sub-disciplines in the core courses is desired, one alternative would be to replace the course *Introduction to Political Science Analysis* with an additional but shorter core course.

Courses will be based on current departmental research while also connecting to broader research agendas within specific topics. While seminars within the core sub-disciplines (comparative politics, political behaviour, and public administration) will be available only to students in the political science programme, other seminars will also be open to students from IAGG. This structure allows the programmes to maintain programme-specific depth while benefiting from pooled resources.

The master seminar courses will typically have approximately 15–20 students and will be based on seminars and individual supervision. Seminar capacity is dimensioned at approximately six seminars per module, assuming that around 60% of students remain at the department during the elective semester. In practice, the proportion remaining at the department has been lower in prior cohorts (on average approximately 45%), which would typically result in smaller seminar groups.²

Beyond offering students more choices, these courses introduce flexibility to the programme, both in terms of instructors involved and the topics offered from year to year. These seminars typically require relatively limited formal course preparation, as they are primarily based on curated literature and seminar discussion. Each seminar will normally be taught by a single instructor.

Courses will run in parallel so that students take two seminar courses of 7.5 credits within a 15-credit module. Administratively, the seminars will be organized as sub-courses within an umbrella course of 15 credits. Forms of assessment may vary and may include seminar presentations, oral examinations, research papers, or methods reports. An example of the structure of a master seminar course is shown in Table 1.

Table 1: Example structure for a master seminar course, 7.5 credits

Week	Activity
1	Seminar 1
2	Seminar 2
3	Seminar 3
4	Seminar 4
5	Mid-term writing / reading
6	Seminar with examination 1
7	Seminar 5
8	Supervision week
9	Examination preparation
10	Final examination and seminar with examination 2

Developing the master’s thesis into a degree project

In recent years, rapid advances in AI have begun transforming how research is conducted. New AI models can assist with coding for empirical work, reviewing texts, drafting research papers, and organizing research workflows. These developments are likely to influence both how research is carried out and the skills students need to develop during their education, raising the question of whether the traditional master’s thesis remains the most appropriate format for the final stage of our programmes.

²Historically, only one to three students choose to study abroad during the elective semester.

The master's thesis has traditionally served as a comprehensive research project that allows students to apply the methodological, analytical, and writing skills they have developed throughout the programme while demonstrating their substantive knowledge. In light of these developments, however, it may be worth reconsidering whether the structure of the thesis course should evolve.

Moreover, the current master's thesis courses are by far the most resource-intensive courses offered in our programmes. In its current form, each thesis requires 20 clock hours of supervision and 12 hours of examination. An additional 60–100 hours are allocated for course coordination, plus 20 hours for coordination of the examination of theses in political science. Altogether, the thesis courses account for roughly 3000 clock hours out of a total programme budget of 5483 clock hours. In other words, more than half of the programme's teaching resources are devoted to a course that constitutes only one quarter of the programme. This raises the question of whether the current structure represents the most effective use of departmental teaching resources.

One way of addressing this issue is to place greater emphasis on the research process leading up to the final product. I propose that the master's thesis be developed into a *degree project*, in which students still independently design and conduct a research project and produce a written research report that is formally examined, but where more structured support is provided throughout the research process.

The proposed degree project course would be allocated approximately 900 clock hours per programme. While this would remain the most resource-intensive course per student and credit, fewer hours would be devoted to individual supervision and more to structured seminars in smaller groups organized around research topics. Under this model, students would participate in four seminar sessions during the semester in groups of approximately seven students, while still receiving four hours of individual supervision. The hours devoted to examination would remain unchanged, and 60 hours would be allocated to course coordination. Students would thus receive both individual supervision and structured peer feedback throughout the semester. This structure also strengthens the research process by allowing students to receive regular peer feedback, discuss methodological and theoretical challenges, and follow the progress of other projects throughout the semester. A further advantage of this structure is that it would allow the department's research environment to be more directly integrated into the course. Researchers could be invited to lead seminars connected to their projects, and students could write their degree projects within the framework of ongoing research.³

Table 2 shows a proposed structure for such a degree project course.

MAPS from Fall 2027

The proposed new structure for MAPS from Fall 2027 is summarized in Table 3. The aim is to create a focused programme that combines in-depth specialization in political science with strong training in methods and research design.

The first semester begins with an introductory block containing two mandatory courses: *Introduction to Political Science Analysis* (SK2122), 7.5 credits, and *Research Design in Political Science* (SK2302), 7.5 credits.⁴

³The maximum length of the final product could be shortened to a standard article length, for example around 12,000 words. The current length is between 6,000 and 20,000 words for the IAGG thesis course and between 6,000 and 16,000 words for MAPS.

⁴As mentioned, if greater representation of sub-disciplines in the core courses is desired, one

Table 2: Proposed budget and structure for a degree project course, 30 credits

Activity	Description	Clock hours
Feedback seminars	Six groups of approximately seven students meet with a teacher for two hours on four occasions during the semester (counted as graded seminars)	192
Individual supervision	Four hours of individual supervision per student	168
Course coordination	Coordination of the course, organization of seminar groups, and examination	60
Examination	12 hours per student allocated for examination	504
Total	Based on 42 students (programme students, Konstanz students, and fee-paying students)	924

The second module of the Fall semester is dedicated entirely to the methods course *Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences* (SK2301), 15 credits. From Fall 2027, this course will require prior completion of a course in research design. The course serves as the core quantitative methods training for MAPS students. It will also be a relatively large course, as it will be offered not only to MAPS students but also to students in IAGG and the Master’s programme in European Studies. By pausing the introductory course in quantitative methods (*Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists*, SF2324) for MAPS students from Fall 2027, and from Fall 2028 for all other students, additional teaching resources can be allocated to the advanced quantitative methods course.

The second semester of the first year is organized around the course *Specialization in Political Science* (30 credits). This course consists of three sub-courses corresponding to central subfields of the discipline: comparative politics, political behavior, and public administration. Each sub-course would normally be worth 10 credits. An alternative structure would be to offer the sub-courses as 7.5 credits each and include a mandatory master’s seminar in political science worth 7.5 credits at the end of the semester. This option would allow students to choose between different seminar themes, for example political theory or international relations.

The Fall semester of the second year is designed as an elective semester. Students may either complete a full-semester internship, combine a half-semester internship with courses in the other half of the semester, or follow a set of master’s seminar and methods courses.

During the first part of the semester (study periods 1–2), students may either begin an internship or take two master’s seminar courses running in parallel. In practice, students would have approximately six seminar courses to choose from, three of them open only to MAPS students.

The second part of the semester (study periods 3–4) places a stronger emphasis on methods. Students may complete the second half of a short internship, take advanced methods seminars within the course *Methodological Specialization* (SK2303),

alternative would be to replace the course *Introduction to Political Science Analysis* with an additional but shorter core course.

Table 3: Proposed structure for MAPS from Fall 2027

Year	Period	Block	Course(s)	Credits
Year 1 – Fall Semester				
	1–2	Introductory courses	Introduction to Political Science Analysis (SK2122)	7.5
			Research Design in Political Science (SK2302)	7.5
	3–4	Methods	Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences (SK2301)	15
Year 1 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Specialization in Political Science (SKXXXX course)	Sub-course: Comparative Politics	10
			Sub-course: Public Administration	10
			Sub-course: Political Behavior	10
		Alternative structure	Sub-course: Comparative Politics	7.5
			Sub-course: Public Administration	7.5
			Sub-course: Political Behavior	7.5
			Master’s Seminar in Political Science (SKXXXX)	7.5
Year 2 – Fall Semester (Elective Semester)				
	1–4	Internship track	Internship (SK2420)	30
	1–2	Internship track	Internship (SK2412)	15
	1–2	Seminar track	Advanced Topics in Political Science (SKXXXX), two master’s seminar courses running in parallel	15
	3–4	Internship track	Internship (SK2412)	15
	3–4	Methods track	Methodological Specialization (SK2303), two methods seminars running in parallel	15
	3–4	Seminar–methods track	One methods seminar and one seminar in another substantive area, running in parallel (AGXXXX)	15
Year 2 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Degree project	Degree Project in Political Science (SKXXXX)	30

or combine a methods seminar with a seminar in another substantive area. These courses will also be open to IAGG students who meet the entry requirements.

The final semester of the programme is dedicated to the degree project (30 credits).

IAGG from Fall 2027

The proposed new structure for IAGG from Fall 2027 is summarized in Table 4. An important feature of the reform is that the structure of the semesters is aligned with that of MAPS. In particular, both programmes would have their primary methods training and their elective semester in the same slots. This alignment allows students who remain at the department during the elective semester to choose courses from both programmes, thereby increasing the number of available options. The reform also addresses a recurring concern among IAGG students that the internship currently takes place too early in the programme.

The first semester begins with an introductory course, *Introduction to International Administration and Global Governance* (AGXXXX, 7.5 credits), which incorporates selected components from the current course AG2110. This introduction is followed by a course in research design specifically designed for IAGG students, *AGXXXX Research Design and Policy Evaluation in the Social Sciences* (7.5 credits).

The second module of the semester is devoted entirely to methods training. Students may choose either the quantitative methods course *Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences* (SK2301) or a methods course offered within the Master's programme in European Studies that focuses on qualitative approaches (SF2323).⁵ In contrast to MAPS, where quantitative methods constitute the main methods training, IAGG students may choose between different methods courses depending on their methodological interests.

The second semester serves as the specialization semester for IAGG. It consists of two specialization courses: *Theoretical and Historical Perspectives on Global Governance* (AG2110) and *International Assistance and Intervention: Impacts of Security and Foreign Aid Policies* (AG2120). Because these courses are now placed after the introductory course, research design training, and methods training, they can be offered at a more advanced level than in the current programme structure.

The third semester functions as the elective semester. Students may complete either a full-semester internship or a shorter internship during either the first or second module of the semester. Alternatively, they may take master's seminar courses that are also open to students in the political science programme. During the first module (study periods 1–2), students choose two master's seminar courses of 7.5 credits each that run in parallel (approximately three courses will be offered for IAGG students). During the second module (study periods 3–4), students may choose between advanced methods seminars, or a combination of one methods seminar and one master's seminar. All these courses are also available to students in the political science programme.

The final semester of the programme is dedicated to the degree project (30 credits).

⁵The European Studies programme may offer a new course that includes both quantitative and qualitative approaches.

Table 4: Proposed structure for IAGG from Fall 2027

Year	Period	Structure	Course(s)	Credits
Year 1 – Fall Semester				
	1–2	Introductory courses	Introduction to International Administration and Global Governance (AGXXXX)	7.5
			Research Design and Policy Evaluation in the Social Sciences (AGXXXX)	7.5
	3–4	Methods (semi-electives)	Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences (SK2301)	15
			Applied Qualitative Research Methods, Problems and Design (SF2323) or similar methods course	15
Year 1 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Specialization	Theoretical and Historical Perspectives on Global Governance (AG2110)	15
			International Assistance and Intervention: Impacts of Security and Foreign Aid Policies (AG2120)	15
Year 2 – Fall Semester (Elective Semester)				
	1–4	Internship track	Internship (AG2450)	30
	1–2	Internship track	Internship (AG2440)	15
	1–2	Seminar track	Two master’s seminar courses running in parallel (AGXXXX)	15
	3–4	Internship track	Internship (AG2440)	15
	3–4	Methods track	Two methods seminars within Methodological Specialization (SK2303)	15
	3–4	Seminar–methods track	One methods seminar and one seminar in another substantive area, running in parallel (AGXXXX)	15
Year 2 – Spring Semester				
	1–4	Degree project	Degree project in International Administration and Global Governance (AGXXXX)	30

Costs in clock hours for different courses

Table 5 provides examples of the approximate teaching costs, measured in clock hours, for different types of courses included in the proposed programme structures. The figures illustrate that different course formats vary substantially in their teaching costs. Methods courses and degree projects are among the most resource-intensive components of the programmes, while seminar courses require considerably fewer clock hours and internships require no teaching hours. The proposed programme structures therefore combine different course formats and make greater use of shared courses and seminar-based teaching in order to balance pedagogical goals with an efficient use of teaching resources.

Table 5: Approximate teaching costs (clock hours) for different course types

Course type (example)	Credits	Clock hours
Introduction courses	7.5	150
Research design courses	7.5	160
Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences (SK2301)	15	500
Specialization courses (core sub-courses MAPS)	10	200
Specialization courses (IAGG)	15	220
Specialization courses (MAPS, alternative structure)	7.5	150
Master's seminar courses / methods seminars	7.5	80
Internship (full semester)	30	0
Internship (half semester)	15	0
Degree project	30	924

Entry requirements

The current entry requirements for MAPS are a bachelor's degree of 180 credits or equivalent, including at least 60 credits in political science (of which at least 30 credits must be from in-depth courses), as well as documented proficiency in English (English 6/English B from Swedish Upper Secondary School or the equivalent level demonstrated through an internationally recognized test such as TOEFL or IELTS).

I propose that applicants to MAPS must have completed at least 5 credits in quantitative methods or statistics (corresponding to the current entry requirement for the course *Advanced Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences* (SK2301)). At the same time, the requirement that 30 of the 60 political science credits must be from in-depth courses should be removed, since this criterion has proven difficult to assess in practice.

I propose that the entry requirements for IAGG remain unchanged. The current entry requirements for IAGG are a bachelor's degree of 180 credits or equivalent, including at least 60 credits in a social science discipline, as well as documented proficiency in English (as described above).

Admission process

The current admission process for MAPS is based on average grades from the bachelor's degree and a statement of intent (introduced from Fall 2026).

Admission to IAGG is currently based on average grades from the bachelor's degree (from Fall 2025), completed courses in relevant subject areas, and a statement of intent. Having at least 60 credits in Political Science, Public Administration, Economics, International Relations, Peace and Conflict Studies, Global Studies, or Development Studies is considered a merit.

I propose that the overall admission procedures should remain unchanged. However, instead of assessing whether applicants have completed 60 credits in relevant subject areas, the selection criteria for IAGG should refer to holding a degree in one of these fields. This change would simplify the assessment process while maintaining the intention of prioritizing applicants with relevant academic backgrounds.

Time plan and implementation

The proposed changes could be implemented starting with student admissions in Fall 2027. At that time, however, students admitted in Fall 2026 under the current programme structures would still be enrolled and completing the second year of their studies. During this transition period, a limited number of courses from the current programme structures would therefore need to continue running to allow the 2026 cohort to complete the programmes under the existing structure.

The transition would proceed as follows:

- **Fall 2027:** The new programme structures are introduced for students admitted in Fall 2027.
- **2027–2028:** Students admitted in Fall 2026 complete the second year of the programmes under the previous structure.
- **From Fall 2028:** All courses in the programmes follow the new structure.

In particular, the course *Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists* (SF2324) would need to run in Fall 2027 in order to accommodate IAGG students admitted in Fall 2026 under the current programme structure (as well as students from the Master's programme in European Studies).

Table 6 lists the courses that would be phased out under the proposed programme structures.

Concluding remarks

This document presents a proposal for revised structures for MAPS and IAGG. The suggested changes aim to strengthen the academic coherence and progression of the programmes, improve methods training, and create greater flexibility. At the same time, the changes aim to use teaching resources more efficiently.

Comments and feedback on the proposal are very welcome.

Table 6: Courses phased out under the proposed programme structures

Last offered	Course
Spring 2027	SK2212 <i>The Quality of Government in a Comparative Perspective</i> (15 credits) SF2222 <i>Citizens, Politicians and the Media: Evaluating Democratic Processes</i> (15 credits) SK2221 <i>Environmental Politics and Institutions</i> (15 credits) SK2222 <i>Varieties of Democracy and Democratization</i> (15 credits)
Fall 2027	SK2211 <i>The Performance of Democracies</i> (15 credits) SF2324 <i>Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists</i> (15 credits)
Spring 2028	SK2532 <i>Master's Thesis</i> (30 credits) AG2500 <i>Master's Thesis for IAGG</i> (30 credits)